

F*CK Adobe

Libre Graphics FTV!

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engineering kiosk meetup alps 09/2026

**Who am I
to talk about this?**

Fair question.

Hi, I'm Romana Mayr

- »» **Graduated from HTL Innsbruck in 2006**
Graphics & Communication Design
- »» **Freelance Illustrator & Graphic Designer**
Working mostly solo
- »» **Worked with Adobe all the way from school**
because that's what you use
- »» **Decided to ditch Adobe in spring 2026**
and get rid of Microsoft too just because...



My most used Adobe tools



Adobe Lightroom

Photo Libraries
(Management),
(RAW-)Development



Adobe Photoshop

Photo Montages &
extended Editing,
Digital Painting



Adobe Illustrator

Logos, Icons,
Vector-Illustrations



Adobe InDesign

(Print-) Layout,
Export for Printing

Why F*CK Adobe?

It works, it's the standard. What do you want?

Main reasons

»» Subscription model & price

Harsh cancellation fee policy. Price hikes. General pricing..

»» Creative Cloud always runs in background

Constantly sucking resources.

»» AI slop combined with cloud storage nudging

The question still lingers if Adobe is training their AI on user content. They say no...

»» Only for macOS and Windows

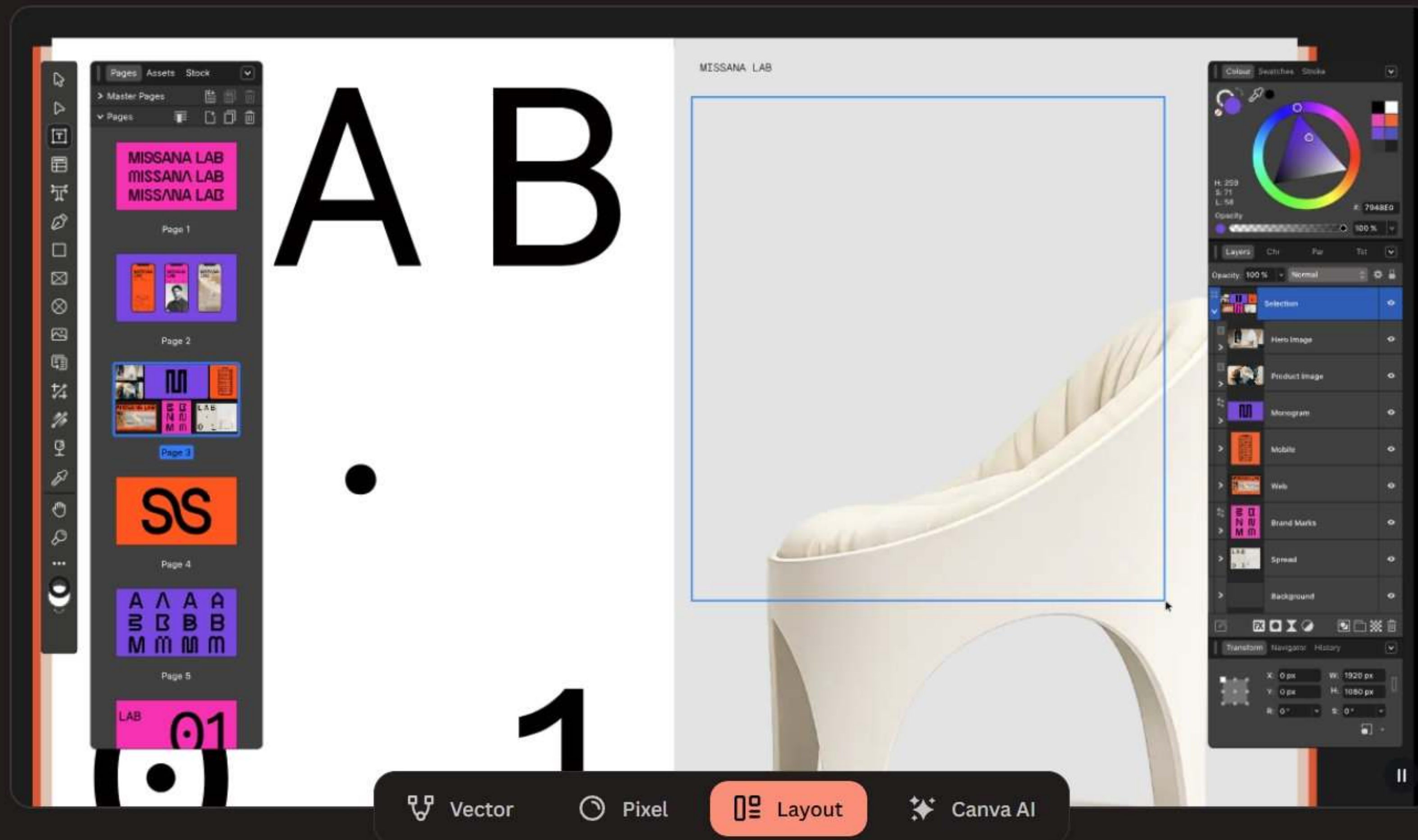
With some entry level stuff available as Browser Apps

**Is there one alternative
to replace it all?**

One can dream...

No more app switching

Design, edit, lay out, then edit again... without ever leaving your .af file. Affinity has all the pro design and photo editing tools you need in one ultra fast, powerful app.



Affinity does it all!

We just have to find some replacement for Lightroom, right?

Zero bucks given

Affinity is free for individuals (seriously). Just choose your preferred platform below to get started. Need Affinity with SSO for your organization? Contact [Canva Enterprise](#) or [Canva Education](#) for more information.

Mac

Fully optimized for macOS. Runs natively on Apple silicon and Intel.

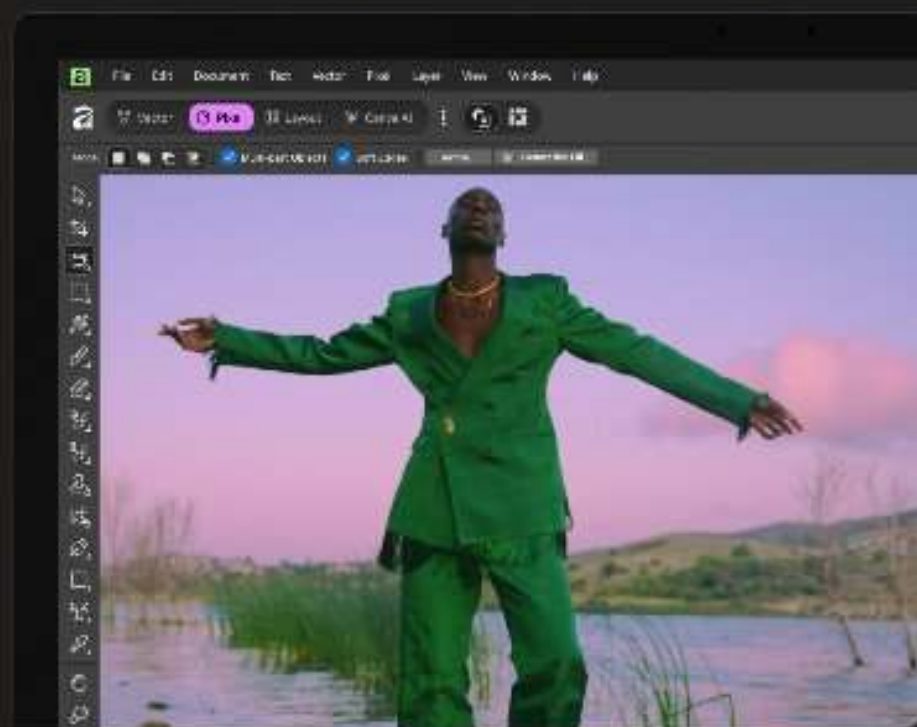
Download for free



Windows

Affinity runs fast even on mid-range machines, but loves a dedicated GPU.

Download for free



iPad

We're busy building our iPad version - stay tuned!

Coming soon!



No Linux
of course...

Plus Canva wants to push you toward using their AI subscription model too...

Want something to work on Linux?

Let's see what's out there!

Adobe Illustrator Alternatives



Inkscape

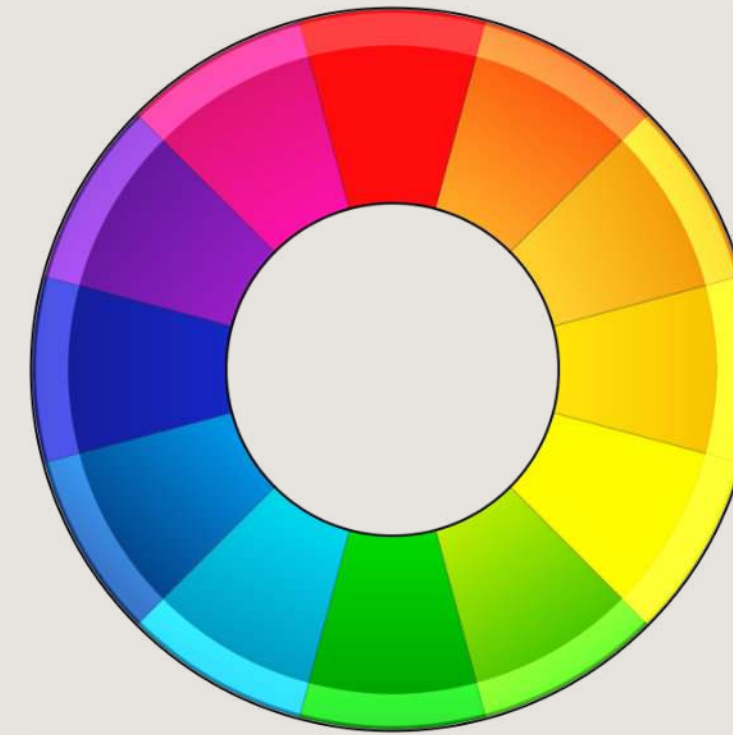


Graphite

Adobe Lightroom Alternatives

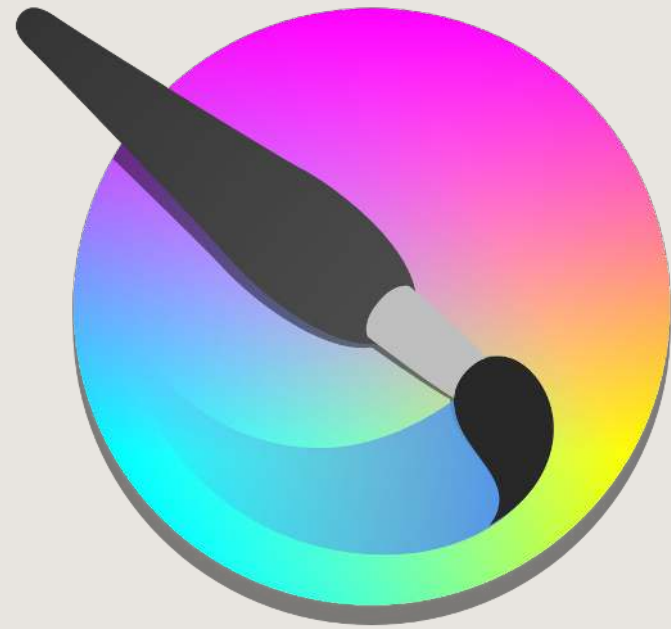


darktable



RawTherapee

Adobe Photoshop Alternatives



Krita



GIMP

Adobe InDesign Alternatives



Scribus



VivaDesigner

Not Free or Open Source
but runs on Linux...

**Do these alternatives
actually work?**

Let's try.

Let's create a flyer for printing

»» Select and tweak some RAW photos

We will use darktable for this one

»» Do some pixel editor magic

Krita here we come

»» We want some icons!

Let's do some vector editing in Inkscape

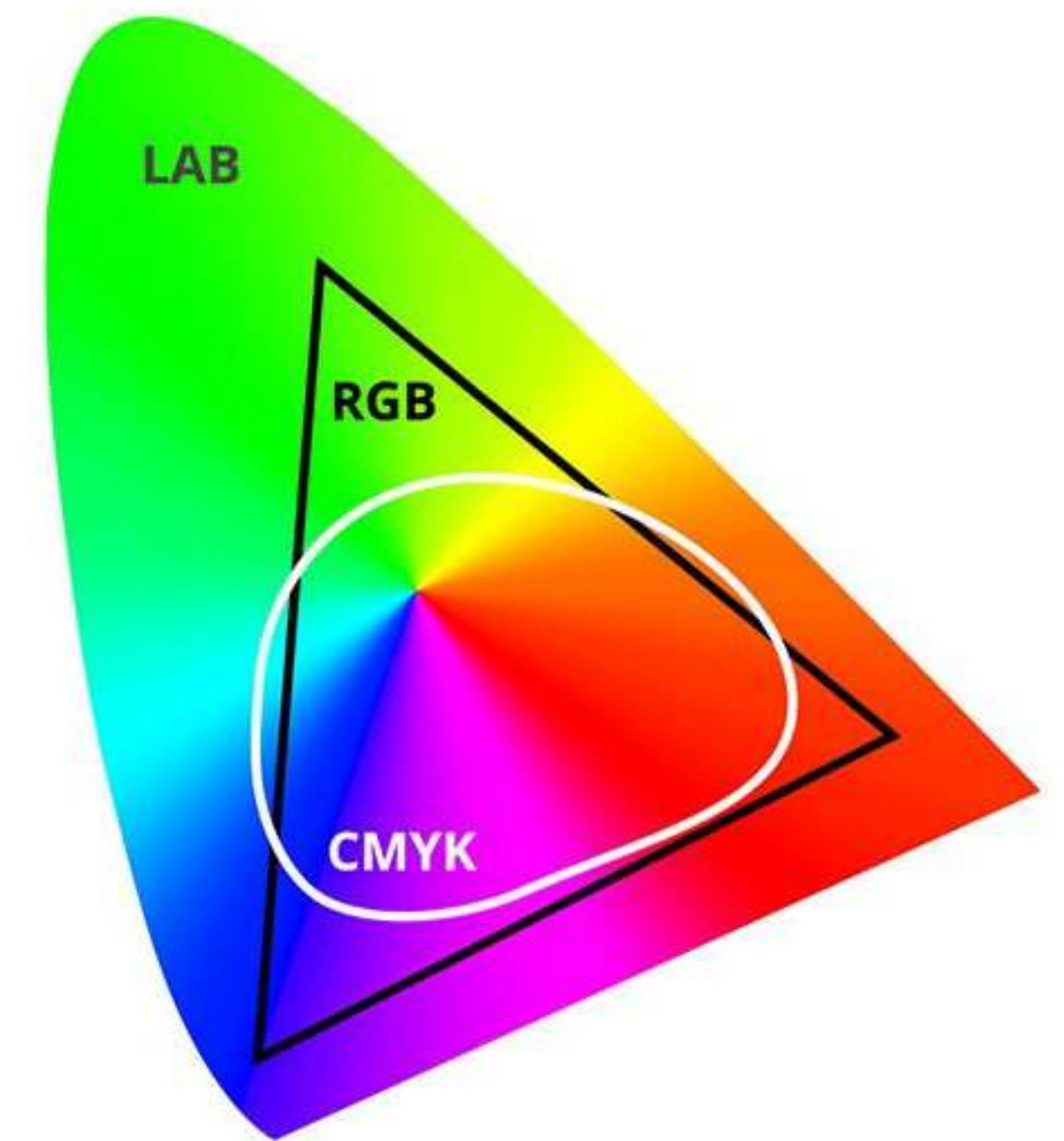
»» Combine everything and export it for printing

Scribus would be the one for this step... Or is it?

Live Demo Time!

Some words on colours

- »» **What you see isn't what you get**
Printing colours (CMYK or Spot Colours) differ
- »» **This is where colour management comes in**
And most of the programs fail
- »» **This is a rabbit hole...**
We are just scratching the surface



Why "*Export as PDF*" isn't enough

»» Specific PDF/X Standards

To lock everything down so the printer sees and prints what we designed.

»» Specific (CMYK) Colour Profiles

Depending on the printer and paper used.

»» Bleeds

Some "space" for cutting and trimming.

»» 300 DPI Resolution

Or otherwise images will get pixelated and blurry.

Main takeaways

Highly personal opinion.

The negatives

- »» **Some alternatives don't use common shortcuts/hotkeys.**

Makes switching real hard. Can be compensated in some with different bindings.

- »» **The UI shows too much and hides too much at the same time**

Creates an unnecessary steep learning curve. Depending on the workflow, hard to use.

- »» **Colour management seems to not be a thing. CMYK support is missing.**

Also spot colours and such. Yes, Scribus does it but...

- »» **Desktop Publishing Software just isn't a thing apparently**

Yes, Scribus is powerful, but not very nice to use coming from the design world.

The positives

- »» **There's a lot out there**

And stuff is happening / ever evolving.

- »» **Some of it is also quite nice to use**

Except the one starting with S...

So, can designers leave Adobe behind?

This was the question in the first place. Wasn't it?

Yes for some

»» If one is working mostly solo

You just can't exchange files. They are not compatible. Importing works, but not for all features. And switching software to and fro just isn't possible.

»» If one is willing to put time and effort into changing one's workflow

Some things work just quite differently. Some don't.

No for others

»» If one is working with others who use Adobe

No interoperability.

»» If one has a very specialized workflow

Might seem obvious, but it works quite differently.

»» All who have to use special colours, profiles etc.

As far as I have found out. Maybe someone will prove me wrong.

What now?

Some things to do

»» If you can, support the software you are using!

Be it with time or money.

»» Spread the word!

Lots of people just don't know that there is anything other than Adobe out there.

Thanks for listening to my ramblings.

I'm very much interested interested
in your experiences, stories and input.

Find me online



roaaar.at